

SK2222: Varieties of Democracy and Democratization

Course Guide Spring 2026

1. Introduction

In the wake of the Cold War, democracy gained the status of a mantra for a while. The number of countries meeting some minimal conditions for democracy increased from around 40 in 1975 to about 100 around 2010. Today the world is in a wave of autocratization. The level of democracy enjoyed by the average global citizen has deteriorated to levels last seen around 1985. The world is almost evenly divided between democracies and autocracies. The question of how to conceptualize and measure political institutions to support meaningful and accurate comparisons through time and across countries such as above is a recurring theme of this class.

Democracy means rule by the people. This common denominator claims a long heritage stretching back to the Classical age. All usages of the term also presume sovereignty. A polity must enjoy some degree of self-government for democracy to be realized. Beyond these two core elements, there is a great debate. The debate covers both descriptive and normative aspects; what political regimes are and what they ought to be. Since an agreement on the definition is necessary for agreeing on how to measure, the two discussions are interlinked. And we need to measure democracy so that we can mark its progress and setback in terms of autocratization and the return of dictatorships, explain the process of democratization, autocratization, or autocratic stability, and reveal their consequences.

For policymakers, activists, academics, and citizens around the world the conceptualization and measurement of democracy and autocracy also matter. Billions of dollars in foreign aid intended to promote or protect democracy and “good governance” are contingent upon judgments about how democratic a polity is, its recent history, development, prospects, and the likely causal effect of particular forms of assistance. Likewise, a large body of work in social science deals with these issues, i.e., the nature, preconditions, causes, consequences, and trajectories of democracy and autocracy around the world. *This course deals with the dynamics of democratization and autocratization from the perspective of theoretical debates, the analysis of historical experiences, as well as immediate policy questions.*

Language of instruction: English

2. Teachers

Staffan I. Lindberg (Course Coordinator) holds a Ph.D. (2005) from Lund University; was assistant professor at Kent State University (2005-2006); assistant/associate professor at University of Florida (2006-2013), and is now professor at University of Gothenburg since 2013; Head, Unifor Policy Research & Founding Director (2012-2025) of the V-Dem Institute; Principal Investigator of *Varieties of Democracy* (V-Dem); Director of the national research infrastructure DEMSCORE; ERC Consolidator; and Wallenberg Academy Fellow alumni. His dissertation won the American Political Science Association's Juan Linz Award for best dissertation 2005 and he is the author of *Democracy and Elections in Africa* (JHUP 2006), co-author of *Varieties of Democracy* (CUP 2020) and *Why Democracy Develops and Declines* (CUP 2022), as well as other books, and some 80 articles on democracy, elections, democratization, autocratization, accountability, clientelism, sequence analysis, women's representation, voting behavior, and other issues. Lindberg also has extensive experience as consultant on development and democracy, and as advisor to international organizations. **Contact:** xlista@gu.se, 031-786-1226, room 464 at Seminariparken, Department of Journalism and Media.

Fabio Angiolillo (Course Coordinator) holds a PhD (2023) in political science from the Hong Kong University (HKU), and he is now a postdoctoral fellow at the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Institute and the University of Gothenburg. His research focuses on autocracies, political parties, political participation, regime stability and change, and political violence in a global perspective but also with a regional focus on East Asia. He won the APSA Political Organizations and Parties Section's Virginia Gray Graduate Research Award

2022 and held research fellowships at Nuffield College, University of Oxford and Cornell University. His research is published in the *British Journal of Political Science*, *Journal of Peace Research*, *Democratization*, and the *Journal of East Asian Studies*. He is co-founder of the Authoritarian Political Systems Group (APSG). **Contact:** fabio.angiolillo@gu.se

Valeriya Mechkova holds a PhD (2022) from University of Gothenburg, and is now an Assistant Professor at the department of Political Science at the same university. Her main research interests concern democracy and political representation, and more specifically how representation and accountability can be used to change the life of ordinary people. Her work has been published in *American Political Science Review*, *Comparative Political Studies*, *World Development*, *Democratization* among others. She is a founder of the Digital Society Project, long-time researcher at V-Dem data, and has experience working as a consultant for the World Bank, USAID, International IDEA and SIDA. **Contact:** valeriya.mechkova@gu.se

Martin Lundstedt is a PhD student at the University of Gothenburg but also worked as researcher at the V-Dem Institute for almost five years before entering the PhD program. His research has focused on electoral integrity, the social and economic dividends of democracy, and the processes of democratization and autocratization. His dissertation focuses on the delegation of decision-making power to unelected officials in democracies. His work has been published in *Electoral Studies*, *Democratization*. He has authored several V-Dem Democracy Reports, and has extensive experience in presenting these findings to a general audience. **Contact:** martin.lundstedt@gu.se

3. Learning Outcomes

A student who has passed the course will be able to:

Knowledge and understanding:

- Compare existing theories and empirical approaches to analyze democracy, autocracy, democratization, and autocratization
- Select appropriate writing skills to develop academic and policy texts in the area of regime stability and change
- Execute small-scale tasks to create unique datasets on democracy

Competence and skills

- Evaluate regime stability and transformation by using all three of the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) datasets (<https://v-dem.net>).
- Formulate research ideas and policy advises by using a variety of writing and oral exposition approaches for research
- Produce a small-scale research and policy projects in the areas of democracy, autocracy, democratization, and/or autocratization, within a given time frame.

Judgment and approach

- Identify patterns of regime transformation in contemporary politics using case studies
- Assess strengths and weaknesses of different approaches to measurement of different concepts of democracy, autocracy, and regime transformation
- Develop approaches on actionable practices to foster democratization and strengthen democratic resilience

4. Course Structure

The course lasts 10 weeks and consists of, in temporal order, four main sections:

The first section discusses concept formation and works that define and measure key concepts of democracy and autocracy. This enables students to be proficient in the literature on varying approaches to democracy and autocracy, and measuring varieties thereof.

- 4 Lectures on the conceptualization, measurement, and analyzing current trends of democratization and autocratization;
- Assessment 1: Multiple Choice Exam on the literature covered in class up to this point;

The second section focuses on explaining processes of regime transformation, i.e. democratization and autocratization. Students learn how countries democratize or autocratize, how to empirically capture these processes and how these processes have changed over the past decades, covering endogenous as well as exogenous theories:

- 2 Lectures on structural and actor-based explanations of democratization and autocratization;
- Assessment 2: Group presentations on predefined topics;

The third section introduces some of the most relevant topics associated with regime stability and change in contemporary politics. This section uses interactive learning to allow students to engage with topics on political parties, democracy promotion, and democratic resilience, and finally provides a learning experience on communicating scientific findings and giving policy advice to policy makers:

- 2 Lectures focusing on key aspects of contemporary challenges: political parties, democracy promotion, and democratic resilience;
- 1 Lecture on translating science to policy advice, and the case for democracy;
- Assessment 3: Individual policy brief papers;

The fourth section consists of writing an individual final course paper.

- 2 Seminars on final paper development on research topics and research design;
- 1 Individual meeting with supervisor for final course paper
- Assessment 4: Final course paper

5. Assessments

Through the course, there will be four assessments:

First assessment: multiple-choice exam on the parts of the course literature covered in class so far, taken in class at an occasion with compulsory attendance. The assessment is done on a scale from 1 to 10 where scores 8-10 is equal to VG, 5-7 is equivalent to G, and lower than 5 is U. It is worth 3 credits.

Second assessment: groups of students' oral presentation on a research question provided by the teacher. The group presentation is followed by a discussion with the teacher and other students. The seminar is compulsory, and absence is associated with a written make-up assignment. The assessment is done on a scale from 1 to 10 where scores 6-10 is equivalent to G, and lower than 6 is U. The group presentation is worth 3 credits.

Third assessment: students are asked to select a research question among those listed for group presentations (students can thus chose to write on the same topic as their own group presented on, or one of the other topics listed) and write a policy brief by applying the research question to one topic from a given selection. Examples of policy briefs are found here on the V-Dem website: <https://v-dem.net/pb.html>. Students are *strongly*

encouraged to study the writing style, structure, and content of the Case for Democracy-series of policy briefs on the V-Dem website. A good idea is to model one's own policy brief on these. The policy brief assignment is max 1,000 words exclusive of references, tables, and figures. As make-up for not submitting on time, students need to write about two additional pages (so around 2,000 words in total instead of the max. 1,000 in the original assignment). The assessment is done on a scale from 1 to 10 where scores 8-10 is equal to VG, 5-7 is equivalent to G, and lower than 5 is U. The policy brief is worth 3 credits.

Fourth assessment is an independent student paper for the course. Course papers should address an issue central to the content of the class. The topic will be selected in consultation with one of the teachers around halfway through the course. The paper should focus on the relevance of the topic, discussion of existing theories and literature, identification of a testable hypothesis (or hypotheses), and study design including detailed reflections on methods and available data. The model for a paper is therefore the introduction, theory, methods and data-sections of an academic article published in an established, peer-review journal such as the articles assigned as readings for the class. Therefore, we do not ask you to empirically test your argument for the final paper. The length should not be less than 5,000 and not exceed 7,000 words, exclusive of references and appendices.

Students are required to submit a *course paper sketch and outline* during the course and before the *final* submission. The sketch of the papers will be discussed among a group of students and supervisors in a seminar workshop. The outline of the paper will be discussed with the final paper supervisors in a one-to-one tutorial of 45 minutes. A central learning outcome of this assignment is to be able to complete a specific research task, using appropriate methods, and *within a predetermined timeframe*.

Should a student fail to hand in this assignment on time by the first hand-in option at the end of the course, a late submission can maximum generate a Pass grade. In order to obtain a Pass with Distinction after the original submission date, a new topic have to be selected by the student in consultation with one of the teachers for submission at a later date and that paper must be completed within approximately the same time period that students have for the paper during the course period. The assessment is done on a scale from 1 to 10 where scores 8-10 is equal to UG, 5-7 is equivalent to G, and lower than 5 is U. The final course paper is worth 6 credits.

Grading Scale

The grading scale comprises: Pass with Distinction (VG), Pass (G) and Fail (U).

To obtain the Pass grade for the course, students must achieve at least a Pass grade on all four graded assignments.

In order to get the grade Pass with Distinction, students must achieve Pass with Distinction on at least one of the multiple-choice or the policy brief paper exams, and a Pass on the group presentation exam, and finally receive Pass with Distinction on the final course paper.

Pass with Distinction requires that the work of the student demonstrate excellent knowledge on the main themes covered by the course, and also demonstrate very good skills to connect theory and empirical design through innovative analyses and to fulfill high academic's and policy practitioners' standards in terms of structure and language, as well as demonstrate the ability to undertake the tasks within a predetermined time frame (i.e. submit on time).

Notes on assignments

- i. Students can be asked to re-work assignments if the grade is "fail" (U) and re-submit them.
- ii. A student who cannot attend a mandatory part of the course will be asked to complete a make-up assignment.
- iii. A student who has taken two exams in a course or part of a course without obtaining a pass grade is entitled

to the nomination of another examiner. The student needs to contact the department for a new examiner, preferably in writing, and this should be approved by the department unless there are special reasons to the contrary (Chapter 6 Section 22 of the Higher Education Ordinance).

- iv. If a student has received a recommendation from the University of Gothenburg for special educational support, where it is compatible with the learning outcomes of the course and provided that no unreasonable resources are required, the examiner may decide to allow the student to sit an adjusted exam or alternative form of assessment.
- v. At least five occasions shall be offered the students to pass a course or part of a course (Chapter 6, Section 21 of Higher Education Ordinance).
- vi. If a course has ceased or undergone major changes, students are to be guaranteed at least three examination sessions (including the ordinary examination session) over a period of at least one year, but no more than two years, after the course has ceased/been changed.

6. Teachers' Expectations and Students' Evaluation

Teachers' Expectation

This is a labor-intensive course that requires extensive reading also beyond the required assignments, as well as active participation by students. It is not a course that focuses exclusively on current events. Rather, it takes a historical and theoretical perspective on several important issues in the comparative study of democratization and autocratization. It is designed to prepare students to excel in further academic or policy analysis endeavors. The average reading load per week is 150-200 pages although some weeks it is less and other weeks it is more, especially in the first half.

Students' Evaluation

The students will be given the opportunity evaluate the course. A summary of the course evaluation and reflections made by the course coordinator must be made available to the students within a reasonable period following completion of the course. The summary and any adjustments made in response to the evaluation shall be presented the next time the course is offered.

7. A Note on Plagiarism

Throughout your time at University, you will write several academic texts (such as analytical papers and literature reviews, home exams and the final thesis). What follows are some of the basic—and hugely important—principles for independent academic writing:

Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the origin of the information and knowledge conveyed by the text.

- Academic texts are characterized by independent and self-designed writing.
- In combination, the above principles mean that in academic writing we use the ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, conclusions of others, but we make clear the origin of these by quoting and referring. We communicate with, build on, and credit previous research, authors, sources, but we do not copy them! Copying is plagiarism, which is the same as cheating.
- Some examples of plagiarism: 1) Copying an existing text. 2) Moving and deleting a few words from an existing text, 3) Translating an existing text from another language. Please note that none of these examples qualify as legitimate academic writing regardless of whether a reference is present or if the text is presented as one's own description and / or analysis.
- There should be no doubt whatsoever in the text about which ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions and conclusions are yours (absent a reference) and which arguments you obtained from other texts (reference to the author included). There are different reference styles (see more about this at <http://www.ub.gu.se/skriva/referensstilar/>) but a good rule of thumb, for maximum transparency, is to include the reference in the text, like this: (author surname, year, page), i.e. (Sikkink, 2000, 13).

- When an author you read uses particular wording to describe something, and you wish to use this exact wording in your text, this wording should be marked as a quote, with a reference that includes a page reference, such as (author surname, year, page). As stated, always including page numbers in the references in the text – whether cited or not – is a good rule of thumb! To put it simply, you avoid plagiarism 1) by always writing independently (never ‘copy and paste’), 2) by quoting, and 3) by the careful and frequent use of references.
- The Department of Political Science uses a control system against plagiarism. Our teachers are also very good at detecting texts that are not self-authored through our own critical reading experience. We are obliged to report suspicion of cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or even a suspension from education.

Additional information and knowledge on ‘Searching and citing,’ ‘Plagiarism,’ ‘Language support’ and a web course on ‘Academic integrity’ is available at UGOT’s student portal. In fact, all the necessary information is gathered at student portal > student environment & rules > disciplinary matters.

8. About Equal Treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Birgitta Niklasson, equal treatment representative Lisbeth Aggestam, or student counselor Sara Birgersson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these people if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if this is not directly aimed at you. All necessary contact information is available on our website.

9. Weekly Schedule

Disclaimer: Students are expected to complete assigned readings *before* a lecture and are responsible for knowing the main issues in all materials discussed in the lectures and readings as well as any handouts. A portion of the material covered in class cannot be found in the required readings. Lectures *reinforce* materials in required readings but also *add* other materials, new concepts, ideas and interpretations. Likewise, some aspects of the assigned readings will not be covered in class but if students have further questions on those aspects or want to discuss them in class, they are welcome to bring them up during the class in question.

Lecture #1: Introduction

Topics: State of democracy in the world; Concept (Mis)Formation, Stretching, Classification, Typologies

Teacher: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 26 March 2026, 8:00-10:00

Mandatory reading:

1. Nord, M., Angiolillo, F., Good God, A., & Lindberg, S. I. 2025. State of the world 2024: 25 years of autocratization – democracy trumped? *Democratization*, 32(4), 839–864.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2487825> (draws and extends on the *Democracy Report 2025*).
2. Collier, David, and James E. Jr. Mahon. "Conceptual 'Stretching' Revisited: Adapting Categories in Comparative Analysis". *American Political Science Review*, vol 84(4), 1993, pp. 845-855.
3. Sartori, Giovanni. "Comparing and Miscomparing". *Journal of Theoretical Politics*, vol 3(3), 1991, pp. 243-257.
4. Collier, David, and Robert Adcock. 1999. "Democracy and Dichotomies: A Pragmatic Approach to Choices About Concepts". *Annual Review of Political Science*, vol 2, 1999, pp. 537- 565.

Supplementary reading:

- Goertz, Gary. *Social Science Concepts and Measurement: New and Completely Revised Edition*. Princeton University Press, 2020.

Lecture #2: Conceptualizing, Measuring, and Analyzing Democracy

Main Question: What are the different Varieties of Democracy? Rationale, theory, methodological approach, and data

Teacher: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 27 March 2026, 13:00-15:00

Mandatory reading:

1. Dahl, Robert. 1971. *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition*. New Haven and London, Yale University Press, pp. 1-16.
2. Dahl, Robert. 1989. *Democracy and Its Critics*. New Haven: Yale University Press, pp. 213-231
3. Coppedge, Michael, Edgell, Amanda, Carl Henrik Knutsen, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2022. "V-Dem Reconsiders Democratization." In Edgell, Amanda, Michael Coppedge, Carl Henrik Knutsen, and Staffan I. Lindberg (eds.) 2022. *How Democracies Develop and Decline*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Chap 1.
4. Teorell, Jan, Michael Coppedge, Svend-Erik Skaaning and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. "Measuring

- Polyarchy Across the Globe, 1900-2017." *Studies in Comparative International Development* 54(1): 71-95. Open access: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12116-018-9268-z>
5. Munck, Gerardo L., and Jay Verkuilen. 2002. "Conceptualizing and Measuring Democracy: Evaluating Alternative Indices." *Comparative Political Studies*, vol 35(1), pp. 5-34.
 6. Lührmann, Anna, Marcus Tannenberg, & Staffan I. Lindberg. 2018. "Regimes of the World (RoW): Opening New Avenues for the Comparative Study of Political Regimes." *Politics and Governance* 6(1). Open access <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.v6i1.1214>

Supplementary reading:

- Gerardo Munck, and Jay Verkuilen. "Generating Better Data: A Response to Discussants," pp.52-7.
- Coppedge, Michael, John Gerring, Staffan I. Lindberg, Svend-Erik Skaaning, and Jan Teorell. 2017. "V-Dem comparisons and contrasts with other measurement projects". University of Gothenburg, Varieties of Democracy Institute, Working Paper No. 45.
- Coppedge, Michael, John Gerring, Carl Henrik Knutsen, Staffan I. Lindberg, Jan Teorell, Kyle L. Marquardt, Juraj Medzihorsky, Daniel Pemstein, Nazifa Alizada, Lisa Gastaldi, Garry Hindle, Josefine Pernes, Johannes von Römer, Eitan Tzelgov, Yi-ting Wang, and Steven Wilson. 2021. "V-Dem Methodology v12". Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project.
- Coppedge, Michael, Staffan I. Lindberg, Svend-Erik Skaaning, and Jan Teorell. 2016. "Measuring High Level Democratic Principles Using the V-Dem Data", *International Political Science Review* 37(5): 580-593. Open access <https://doi.org/10.1177/0192512115622046>
- Marshall, Monty G., Ted Robert Gurr, and Keith Jagers. 2019. "Polity IV Project: Political Regime Characteristics and Transitions, 1800-2018. Dataset Users' Manual". Center for Systemic Peace.
- Alvarez, Mike, José Antonio Cheibub, Fernando Limongi, and Adam Przeworski. 1996. "Classifying Political Regimes." *Studies in International Comparative Development* 31(2), pp. 3-36.
- Sigman, Rachel & Staffan I. Lindberg. 2018. "Democracy for All: Conceptualizing and Measuring Egalitarian Democracy", *Political Science Research and Methods* 7(3): 595- 612. Open access <https://doi.org/10.1017/psrm.2018.6>

Lecture #3: Conceptualizing, Measuring, and Analyzing Autocracy

Main Question: What are the different Varieties of Autocracy? Rationale, theory, methodological approach, and data

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo

Time: 1 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

Mandatory reading:

1. Svolik, M. (2012). *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. doi:10.1017/CBO9781139176040, Chapters 4 and 6.
2. Meng, Anne. "Constraining Dictatorship: From Personalized Rule to Institutionalized Regimes". Cambridge University Press, 2020, Chapter 3
3. Gandhi J. *Political Institutions under Dictatorship*. Cambridge University Press; 2008. Chapters 1 and 3
4. Pepinsky, T. (2014). The institutional turn in comparative authoritarianism. *British Journal of Political Science*, 44(3), 631-653.
5. Geddes, Barbara, Joseph Wright and Erica Frantz. "Autocratic Breakdown and Regime Transitions: A New Data Set". *Perspectives on Politics*, vol 12 (02), 2014, pp. 313–331.

Supplementary reading (NOTE: SELECT AT LEAST ONE FURTHER READING FROM THE LIST)

- Wright, Joseph. "The Latent Characteristics that Structure Autocratic Rule". *Political Science Research and Methods*, vol.9, 2021, 1-19
- Gerring, John, Wig, Tore, Veenendaal, Wouter, Weitzel, Daniel, Toerell, Jan, and Kikuta, Kyosuke. "Why Monarchy? The Rise and Demise of a Regime Type". *Comparative Political Studies*. vol.54(3-4), 2021, pp. 585-622
- Cheibub, José Antonio, Jennifer Gandhi, and James Raymond Vreeland. "Democracy and Dictatorship revisited". *Public Choice*, vol 143, 2010, pp. 67-101.
- Way, Lucan, and Steven Levitsky. "Elections Without Democracy: The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism". *Journal of Democracy*, vol 13(2), 2002, pp. 51-65.
- Lachapelle, J., Levitsky, S., Way, L., & Casey, A. (2020). Social Revolution and Authoritarian Durability. *World Politics*, 72(4), 557-600. doi:10.1017/S0043887120000106.
- Koss, Daniel. "Where the Party Rules. The Rank and File of China's Communist State". Cambridge University Press, Chapter 2

Lecture #4: Measuring and Analyzing Democratization and Autocratization

Main Question: How can we measure regime change? Theories and methodological approaches

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo

Time: 7 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

Mandatory reading

1. Huntington, S. P. 1991. Democracy's third wave. *Journal of democracy*, 2(2), 12-34.
2. Lührmann, Anna and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. A Third Wave of Autocratization is Here: What is New About It? *Democratization* 26 (7), 1095-1113. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2019.1582029>
3. Knutsen, Carl Henrik and Svend-Erik Skaaning. 2022. "The Ups and Downs of Democracy, 1789-2018." In Edgell, Amanda, Michael Coppedge, Carl Henrik Knutsen, and Staffan I. Lindberg (eds.) 2022. *How Democracies Develop and Decline*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Chap. 2
4. Skaaning, Svend-Erik. 2020. "Waves of Autocratization and Democratization: a Critical Note on Conceptualization and Measurement." *Democratization* 27, no. 8: 1533–1542. doi:10.1080/13510347.2020.1799194.
5. Maerz, Seraphine F. and Edgell, Amanda and Wilson, Matthew C. and Hellmeier, Sebastian and Lindberg, Staffan I. 2021 "A Framework for Understanding Regime Transformation: Introducing the ERT Dataset." *Journal of Peace Research*

Supplementary reading:

- Strand, H., Hegre, H., Gates, S., & Dahl, M. 2012. Why waves? Global patterns of democratization, 1820–2008. Typescript, PRIO.
- Tomini, Luca. 2021. "Don't think of a wave! A research note about the current autocratization debate." *Democratization* 28.6: 1191-1201.
- Wilson, Matthew C., Juraj Medzihorsky, Seraphine F. Maerz, Patrik Lindenfors, Amanda B. Edgell, Vanessa A. Boese, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2022. "Episodes of liberalization in autocracies: a new

- approach to quantitatively studying democratization." *Political Science Research and Methods*: 1-20.
- Boese, Vanessa, Anna Lührmann, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2021. "Waves of autocratization and democratization: A rejoinder." *Democratization* 28 (x), Open access: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2021.1923006>
-

Assignment #1: Multiple Choice Exam

Topics: EXAMINATION

Examiner: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 10 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

The purpose of the multiple-choice exam is to measure the extent to which students have read and understood the course literature assigned for lectures 1 through 4. The test will be written and consisting of multiple-choice questions on the content, arguments, and findings found in the assigned literature. An example of a question and multiple-choice answers would be:

In "The Latent Characteristics that Structure Autocratic Rule" Wright (2021) argues that:

- A. Systematic information about how dictatorships work should reflect informal aspects. Wright use old data and explores three manifest dimensions that contain substantially the same information as existing measures but use them to show new aspects. He shows that the first dimension captures the strength of personal rule, the second institutional strength, and that the third measures executive power.
- B. Systematic information about how dictatorships work should reflect formal aspects. Wright introduce new data and explores three dimensions of autocratic rule that contain substantially different information than existing measures. He shows that the first dimension captures the strength of party rule, the second the military's constitutional role, and that the third dimension measures the extent to which the ruler's personal power is strong.
- C. Systematic information about how dictatorships work should reflect informal aspects. Wright introduce new data that capture informal aspects and explores three latent dimensions of autocratic rule that contain substantially different information than existing measures. He shows that the first dimension captures the strength of party rule, the second the military's institutional strength vis-a-vis the party and the leader, and that the third dimension measures the extent to which the ruler has a guiding ideology.
- D. Systematic information about how dictatorships work should reflect informal aspects. Wright introduce new data that capture informal aspects and explores three latent dimensions of autocratic rule that contain substantially different information than existing measures. He shows that the first dimension captures the strength of party rule, the second the military's institutional strength vs. the party and the leader, and that the third measures personalist power.

Rules:

- 10-20 questions on the literature of the course up till this point, with multiple choice answers
- Each correct answer assigns 0,5-1 point

- The grading scale comprises:
 - 8-10 = Pass with Distinction (VG),
 - 5-7 = Pass (G)
 - <5 = Fail (U)
-

Lecture #5: Structural and Actor-Based Explanations of Democratization

Main Question: What are the main causes leading up to democratization?

Teacher: Valeriya Mechkova

Time: 14 April 2026, 15:00-17:00

Mandatory reading:

1. Edgell, Amanda, Michael Coppedge, Carl Henrik Knutsen, and Staffan I. Lindberg (eds.) 2022. *How Democracies Develop and Decline*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Chap 5-7.
2. Riedl, R., Slater, D., Wong, J. and Ziblatt, D. (2020). Authoritarian-Led Democratization. *Annual Review of Political Science*, vol. 23:1.
3. Acemoglu, D., & Robinson, J. A. 2005. *Economic origins of dictatorship and democracy*. Cambridge university press. From PART ONE: Chapter 2. Our argument (p. 15-30)
4. Treisman, D. (2020) Economic development and democracy: predispositions and triggers. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 23(1), pp.241-257.
5. Edgell, Amanda B., Valeriya Mechkova, David Altman, Michael Bernhard & Staffan I. Lindberg. "When and where do elections matter? A global test of the democratization by elections hypothesis, 1900–20
6. Scheve, K. and Stasavage, D. (2017). Wealth inequality and democracy. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 20, pp.451-468.

Supplementary Reading:

- Teorell, Jan. 2010. *Determinants of Democratization - Explaining Regime Change in the World, 1972-2006*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Chapter 1 "Explaining democratization".
- Haggard, S. and Kaufman, R.R. (2012) *Inequality and Regime Change: Democratic Transitions and the Stability of Democratic Rule*. *American Political Science Review*, Vol. 106(3), 495-516.
- Kim, N.K., and Kroeger, A.M. (2019) Conquering and coercing: Nonviolent anti-regime protests and the pathways to democracy. *Journal of Peace Research*, 56(5), 650-666.
- Treisman, D. (2020). Democracy by Mistake: How the Errors of Autocrats Trigger Transitions to Freer Government. *American Political Science Review*, 114(3), 792-810. doi:10.1017/S0003055420000180.
- Dahlum, S., Knutsen, C.H., and Wig, T. (2019) Who Revolts? Empirically Revisiting the Social Origins of Democracy. *The Journal of Politics*, 81(4), 1494-1499.

Lecture #6: Structural and Actor-Based Explanations of Autocratization

Main Question: What are the main causes leading up to autocratization?

Teacher: Valeriya Mechkova

Time: 17 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

Mandatory reading:

1. Gerschewski, J. 2021. "Erosion or decay? Conceptualizing causes and mechanisms of democratic regression." *Democratization* 28.1: 43-62.
2. Waldner, D., and Lust, E. 2018. "Unwelcome Change: Coming to Terms with Democratic Backsliding". *Annual Review of Political Science*, vol. 21(5): 5.1-5.21.
3. Graham, M. H., and Svobik, M. W. 2020. "Democracy in America? Partisanship, Polarization, and the Robustness of Support for Democracy in the United States." *American Political Science Review*.
4. Linz, Juan J. "The perils of presidentialism." *J. Democracy* 1 (1990): 51.
5. Zhuravskaya, E., Petrova, M. and Enikolopov, R., 2020. Political effects of the internet and social media. *Annual Review of Economics*, 12, pp.415-438.

Supplementary Reading:

- Diamond, L. 2015. "Facing up to the democratic recession." *Journal of Democracy* 26.1: 141-155.
- Bermeo, Nancy. "On democratic backsliding." *Journal of Democracy* 27, no. 1 (2016): 5-19.
- Orhan, Yunus Emre. "The relationship between affective polarization and democratic backsliding: comparative evidence." *Democratization* 29.4 (2022): 714-735.
- McKay, Spencer, and Chris Tenove. "Disinformation as a threat to deliberative democracy." *Political Research Quarterly* 74.3 (2021): 703-717.
- O'Donnell, Guillermo. "Horizontal accountability in new democracies." *J. Democracy* 9 (1998): 112.

Assignment #2: (Group) Presentations

Topics: EXAMINATION

Examiner: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 21 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

A second assessment of students' command of the literature, understanding of content covered by lectures, and ability to independently understand and use appropriately existing theories, is done by seminars where groups of students present on a topic provided by the teacher.

The class will be divided in working groups, the size of which is determined by the number of students registered in the class. Each group should use a minimum of two articles or book chapters among the assigned literature, and a minimum of two other articles the students have found themselves, to answer the research question their groups has been assigned. The reading groups will be posted on Canvas when the registration for the class has finished.

Your presentations should include both a theoretical argument answering the question you have been assigned, as well as empirical evidence from the literature. At the end of the presentation, you should offer brief reflections about potential strengths and weaknesses of the articles you have read and present your group's critical assessment.

Rules:

- The seminar is compulsory and absence is associated with a make-up, written assignment. The make-up assignment is to write a paper of 3-5 pages where you discuss the articles you were initially

assigned.

- Each group will be composed by 2 to 4 students, and will be assigned a specific topic
- Each group members should prepare an oral presentation based on the literature covered in class so far but should also search for additional literature (5-10 articles, or a particularly relevant book or two) on the topic and bring that to bear on the presentation.
- Each presenting group will have 12 minutes allocated for the oral presentation, and students should use some form of supporting presentation material – for example power point slides.
- After the presentation, discussion will follow for 10-12 minutes. Students participating in the class should be prepared to ask questions to their classmates after each presentation. Active participation count as a + on the final grade for assignment #2.
- The grading scale comprises: Pass (G) and Fail (U).
- Group presentation and seminar participation is worth 3 credits.

Topics for the presentations:

1. Under what conditions may we expect autocratic rulers to lead democratization processes themselves?
 2. In what way does the state of the economy affect prospects for democratization?
 3. Are elections more likely to lead to democratization or autocratic stability?
 4. When and why should we expect political polarization to promote autocratization?
 5. Are specific setup of institutions more likely to lead to autocratization?
 6. Does social media promote democratization or autocratization?
- You will receive a score from 1-10, and your grade will be given based on:
 - Oral communication (0-5)
 - Academic content (0-3)
 - Supporting material (e.g., slides etc.) (0-2)
 - Active engagement in discussion (0-1)
 - The grading scale comprises:
 - ≥ 6 = Pass (G)
 - < 6 = Fail (U)
-

Lecture #7: International Democracy Promotion

Main Question: What are the effects of democracy promotion?

Teacher: Staffan I Lindberg

Time: 23 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

CURRENT DEBATES #1

Mandatory reading:

1. Leininger, J., & Richter, S. (2023). From democracy promotion to democracy protection. In D. Caramani (Ed.), *Comparative politics* (6th ed., pp. 476-494). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
2. Carothers, T. (2020). Rejuvenating democracy promotion. *Journal of Democracy*, 31(1), 114-123.
3. Gisselquist, R. M., Niño-Zarazua, M., & Samarin, M. (2021). Does aid support democracy? A systematic review of the literature. WIDER Working Paper No. 2021/14. The United Nations World Institute for Development Economics Research (UNU-WIDER): Helsinki.

Supplementary reading:

- Hyde, S. D., Lamb, E., & Samet, O. (2023). Promoting democracy under electoral authoritarianism: Evidence from Cambodia. *Comparative Political Studies*, 1029-1071.
- Bouchet, N., Godfrey, K., & Youngs, R. (2022). Rising hostility to democracy support: Can it be countered? Retrieved from <https://carnegieeurope.eu/2022/09/01/rising-hostility-to-democracy-support-can-it-be-counterred-pub-87745>
- Dodsworth, S., & Cheeseman, N. (2018). Ten challenges in democracy support – and how to overcome them. *Global Policy*, 9(3), 301-312.
- Grimm, S., & Leininger, J. (2012). Not all good things go together: conflicting objectives in democracy promotion. *Democratization*, 19(3), 391-414.
- Heinrich, T., & Loftis, M. W. (2019). Democracy aid and electoral accountability. *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 63(1), 139-166.

Lecture #8: Political Parties and Regime Transformation

Main Question: What are roles parties can play for regime transformation?

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo

Time: 27 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

CURRENT DEBATES #3

Mandatory Readings:

1. Angiolillo, F., Wiebrecht, F., & Lindberg, S. I. (2025). Party Systems, Democratic Positions, and Regime Changes: Introducing the Party-System Democracy Index. *British Journal of Political Science*
2. Medzihorsky, J., & Lindberg, S. I. (2023). Walking the Talk: How to Identify Anti-Pluralist Parties. *Party Politics*
3. Svobik, M. W., Avramovska, E., Lutz, J., & Milaèia, F. (2023). In Europe, Democracy Erodes from the Right. *Journal of Democracy*, 34(1), 5-20.
4. Gandhi, J., & Ong, E. (2019). Committed or conditional democrats? Opposition dynamics in electoral autocracies. *American Journal of Political Science*, 63(4), 948-963.
5. Loxton, J., & Mainwaring, S. (Eds.). (2018). *Life after dictatorship: authoritarian successor parties worldwide*. Cambridge University Press. Pp. 1-50
6. Slater, D., & Wong, J. (2013). The Strength to Concede: Ruling Parties and Democratization in Developmental Asia. *Perspectives on Politics*, 11(3), 717–733. doi:10.1017/S1537592713002090

Supplemental Readings:

- Laebens, M. G., & Öztürk, A. (2021). Partisanship and autocratization: Polarization, power asymmetry, and partisan social identities in Turkey. *Comparative Political Studies*, 54(2), 245-279.
- Miller, M. K. (2021). Don't call it a comeback: autocratic ruling parties after democratization. *British Journal of Political Science*, 51(2), 559-583.
- Svobik, M. W. (2023). Voting Against Autocracy. *World Politics*, 75(4), 647-691.
- LeBas, A. (2011). *From protest to parties: Party-building and democratization in Africa*. Oxford University Press. Pp.1-50
- Grzymala-Busse, A. (2020). Consequences of authoritarian party exit and reinvention for democratic

competition. *Comparative Political Studies*, 53(10-11), 1704-1737.

- Tavits, M. (2012). Organizing for success: party organizational strength and electoral performance in postcommunist Europe. *The Journal of Politics*, 74(1), 83-97.

Lecture #9: Translating Science to Policy Advise, and the Case for Democracy

Main Question: What are the dividends of democratic governance? How to communicate effectively in a policy setting?

Teacher: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 29 April 2026, 13:00-15:00

CURRENT DEBATES #3a

Mandatory reading:

1. Lundstedt, Martin, Felix Wiebrecht, Vanessa Boese-Schlosser, Kelly Morrison, Natalia Natsika, Marina Nord, Evie Papada, Yuko Sato, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2023. *Case for Democracy Report*. V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg. (https://v-dem.net/thematic_reports.html)
2. Hegre, H. (2014). Democracy and armed conflict. *Journal of Peace Research*, 51(2), 159- 172.
3. Acemoglu, D., Naidu, S., Restrepo, P., & Robinson, J. (2019). Democracy Does Cause Growth. *Journal of Political Economy*, 127(1), 47-100.
4. Bollyky, T. J., Templin, T., Cohen, M., Schoder, D., Dieleman, J. L., & Wigley, S. (2019). The Relationships between Democratic Experience, Adult Health, and Cause-Specific Mortality in 170 Countries between 1980 and 2016: An Observational Analysis. *The Lancet*, 393(10181), 1628-1640.

Supplementary reading (all available at: <http://v-dem.net/pb.html>):

2. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2022. *Case for Democracy: Does Democracy Have Dividends for Education?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 35, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg.
3. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2022. *Case for Democracy: Democracies Produce More Transparent and Higher-Quality Data*. V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 34, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg.
4. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2022. *Case for Democracy: Does Democracy Improve Public Goods Provision?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 33, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg.
5. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2021. *Case for Democracy: Do Democracies Perform Better Combatting Climate Change?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 31, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg
6. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2021. *Case for Democracy: Does Democracy Bring International and Domestic Peace and Security?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 30, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg
7. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2021. *Case for Democracy: Does Democracy Increase Global Health?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 29, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg
8. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2021. *Case for Democracy: Are Democracies Better for Social Protection of the Poor, Gender Equality, and Social Cohesion?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 28, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg
9. Varieties of Democracy Institute. 2021. *Case for Democracy: Does Democracy Cause Economic Growth, Stability, and Work for the Poor?* V-Dem Policy Brief, No. 27, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg

Assignment #3: Policy Brief Hand-in

Topics: EXAMINATION

Examiner: Staffan I. Lindberg

Time: 4 May 2026, 15:00

Rules:

The course literature in this module covered several key current theoretical debates for the drivers of autocratization, democratization, and democratic resilience. For this assignment, pick one of the following research questions and combine it with a topic area you want (this can be the question your group presented on in Assignment #2, or another one).

Students are *strongly* encouraged to first study the Case for Democracy policy brief-series on the V-Dem website carefully. The assignment is to write an original text that is modeled on those policy briefs in terms of style of presentation, writing and presentation techniques, structure, as well as content management. This is an exercise in non-academic writing and presentation aimed at a thought audience of policy-practitioners in the international democracy support community.

You should pick a combination of one of the questions and one of the topics listed below, and it should be clear from the text of the policy brief which ones you picked, but each student is encouraged to formulate a more appealing, catchy, attention-grabbing heading for their policy brief, and are encouraged to narrow down the scope of the question for the purposes of the policy brief.

Research Question	Topic Areas
a. Under what conditions may we expect autocratic rulers to lead democratization processes themselves?	I. Parties' and party systems' commitment to democracy
b. In what way does the state of the economy affect prospects for democratization?	II. Democratic promotion and protection
c. Are elections more likely to lead to democratization or autocratic stability?	III. Political institutions
d. When and why should we expect political polarization to promote autocratization?	IV. Climate change
e. Are specific setup of institutions more likely to lead to autocratization?	V. Digital technologies
f. Under what conditions may democratic opposition stop autocratization?	VI. Education

Disclaimer: You can pick the question you have been assigned in Assignment #2 and apply that question to one of these topics or choose a different question. We strongly suggest you to keep working on the same research question to delve deeper in finding key answers.

Max. 1,000 words - exclusive of the list of references, table and or figure, and any graphs/tables you may want to use and put in an appendix.

Please include a word count.

- The grading scale comprises:
 - 8-10 = Pass with Distinction (VG),
 - 5-7 = Pass (G)
 - <5 = Fail (U)
-

Assignment #4: Final Paper Sketch Hand-in

Topics: Sketch

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo, Martin Lundstedt, Valeriya Mechkova

Time: 7 May 2026, 15:00

Rules:

The sketch should to the best of your ability contain:

1. Introduction of the issue/puzzle you are interested in.
2. Briefly discuss the literature you know of that has something to say about this problem/puzzle/issue
3. Identify the "research gaps" - what the literature has not provided an answer to, or not a good enough answer.
4. **Formulate a tentative research question and a hypothesis about the answer to the question. (think about your X and Y)**
5. Discuss what type(s) of data you would need to evaluate this hypothesis and provide an answer to the question, and which type(s) of empirical analysis you would do.
6. List of references (does not count towards the page limit)

The sketch does not have to contain regular text (bullets are fine) but all six points (above) should be mentioned. 2 pages max.

Seminar #1: Final Paper Discussions

Main Question: What is your selected topic for the final assignment and why?

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo, Valeriya Mechkova, Martin Lundstedt

Time: 11 May 2026, 13:00-15:00

What to prepare:

This is a student-led seminar where you will discuss your ideas for the final paper with your peers and evaluate strengths and weaknesses of the literature on the selected argument, and how you plan on focusing for your final paper. The teacher will be there to moderate.

Seminar #2: Developing Your Research Design

Main Question: How are you designing your research design?

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo

Time: 13 May 2025, 13:00-15:00

What to prepare:

This seminar is dedicated to extensively discuss research design. What are the best practices for the final paper sketch you presented?

Assignment #4: Final Paper Outline Hand-in

Topics: Final Outline

Time: 18 May 2026, 15:00

Rules:

The Outline should to the best of your ability contain:

1. Introduction of the issue/puzzle you are interested in.
2. Briefly discuss the literature you know of that has something to say about this problem/puzzle/issue
3. Identify the "research gaps" - what the literature has not provided an answer to, or not a good enough answer.
4. **Formulate a research question and a hypothesis about the answer to the question. (think about your X and Y)**
5. Outline a clear research design comprehensive of details on data you would use and how you plan on empirically testing your argument.
6. List of references (does not count towards the page limit)

The outline should contain some fully formulated paragraphs but still does not have to be a regular text. It should be 3-4 pages maximum.

Individual Meetings: Discussion Towards Final Assignment

Main Topic: Discussing your final paper outline

Teacher: Fabio Angiolillo, Martin Lundstedt, Valeriya Mechkova

Duration: 30 minutes

Time: 21 May 2026, upon agreement

What to prepare:

You will discuss your final paper outline with your supervisor in a one-to-one meeting. We suggest you prepare detailed questions on doubts or areas you would like to discuss with us.

Assignment #4: Final Paper Hand-in

Topics: EXAM

Time: 5 June 2026, 15:00

Resubmission #1: 22 August 2026, 15:00

Resubmission #2: 10 October 2026, 15:00

Content:

The model for a paper is an academic article published in an established, peer-review journal, such as the articles/chapters assigned as readings for the class. The length should not be less than 5,000 but not longer than 7,000 words, exclusive of references. A very central learning outcome of this assignment is to be able to complete a specific research task using appropriate methods and within a predetermined timeframe.

- **Topic:**
 - An issue central to the content of the class.
 - Selected in consultation with the teacher.
- **Structure:**
 - Like academic articles published in an established, peer-review journal such as the articles/chapters assigned as readings for the class but with a focus on the parts leading up to the empirical analysis.
 - Length: 5,000 -7,000 words, exclusive of references.
- **Research Design:**
 - Students can choose either qualitative or quantitative research design
 - If you want to follow a **qualitative approach**: write a comparative case study of one or more countries.
 - **Strong advice**: do not write about your home country. If you do, compare it to a set of other countries (e.g. three more).
 - We **do not** expect you execute the empirical analysis for this course, but you should have a compelling introduction of the topic, in-depth discussion of theory and existing literature, identify a testable hypothesis (or hypotheses), and provide and reflect upon a detailed research design including methods and data, that would make for a sound academic empirical investigation.
- **Goal:**
 - Learning outcome: be able to complete a specific research task, using appropriate methods, and within a predetermined timeframe.
 - Develop a research question/hypothesis based on the course content and answer it.
- **Late Submission:**
 - *Should a student fail to hand in this assignment on time, a late submission can maximum generate a Pass grade.*
 - *In order to obtain a Pass with Distinction after the original submission date, a new topic will have to be selected by the student in consultation with the teacher for submission at a later date, and a new paper be written within a time frame that approximates the time allotted during the course period.*